ADVANCED MATERIALS ENGINEERING

Process Drift in Injection Molding: Why Scrap Rises Months Before Anyone Notices

Joshua Otaigbe · February 15, 2027

Most molding problems do not start with a dramatic failure. They start with a scrap rate that creeps from acceptable to irritating over a few months, a dimension that drifts toward the edge of tolerance, or a part family that passes inspection but generates a slow trickle of customer complaints. By the time the problem is obvious, the process has often been "adjusted" several times by well-meaning technicians, and the original cause is buried under a stack of compensations.

In automotive supply, where parts are qualified through a formal approval process and customers expect consistent output for years, this kind of drift is expensive twice: once in scrap and rework, and again in the credibility lost when a qualified part starts behaving differently.

Why drift is so hard to see

An injection molding process is a chain of interacting variables: material condition, melt temperature, residence time, injection speed, pack pressure, mold temperature and cooling. A molding machine's controls are designed to hold setpoints, and modern machines hold them very well. The trouble is that a setpoint is not the same as the condition the material actually experiences. A barrel can hold its temperature profile perfectly while the resin inside it degrades because cycle time has lengthened. A dryer can display the right temperature while delivering wet material because the airflow is restricted.

Drift also hides behind compensation. When parts start short-shooting, someone raises pressure. When they flash, someone lowers it. Each change fixes the symptom and moves the process further from its validated window. Over months, the process that is running is no longer the one that was qualified, and nobody decided that it should change.

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The material side of drift

For engineering resins used in automotive parts, a large share of slow-building problems trace back to what happens to the polymer before and during molding.

Moisture

Polyamides (PA6 and PA66), PBT, PET and polycarbonate are all moisture sensitive, but in different ways. Polyesters and polycarbonate undergo hydrolysis if they are molded wet: water attacks the polymer chains at melt temperatures and cuts molecular weight, producing parts that look normal but are brittle. Polyamides can also be degraded by excessive moisture, and in addition they suffer if they are over-dried for long periods, which can cause yellowing and oxidative damage. A dryer that is undersized for the current throughput, a hopper left open, or a material handling change that adds time between dryer and press can all shift moisture content gradually.

Residence time

The time the melt spends in the barrel matters as much as its temperature. If a mold is moved to a larger press, or the cycle lengthens because of a cooling problem, residence time rises and thermal degradation increases. Flame-retarded and glass-filled grades are often especially sensitive.

Regrind

Regrind ratios tend to rise quietly under cost pressure. Every pass through the barrel reduces molecular weight and breaks glass fibers in reinforced grades, which reduces strength and stiffness. A regrind ratio set at qualification can be exceeded routinely on the floor without anyone formally changing the process.

Fiber length in reinforced grades

Glass-filled polyamides and polyesters dominate structural automotive plastics, and their stiffness and strength depend heavily on the length of the glass fibers in the finished part. Fibers are shortened by high screw speeds, high back pressure, restrictive nozzles and gates, and every pass of regrind. A part can contain exactly the specified glass content and still be markedly weaker than the qualified part because the fibers have been chopped shorter. Fiber length is rarely monitored in production, which makes it one of the most common hidden variables behind a slow loss of strength. It can be measured by burning off the polymer from a sample and analyzing the residual

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fibers under a microscope, a simple test that often resolves arguments about whether material or process changed.

Fiber orientation and weld lines

Changes in gate location, injection speed or melt temperature alter how fibers align in the part, and that alignment controls strength, shrinkage and warpage. Weld lines, where flow fronts meet, are especially sensitive: fibers do not cross the weld efficiently, and weld-line strength in filled grades can be a fraction of the bulk value. A process change that moves a weld line into a loaded area can turn a reliable part into a field failure without any change in material at all.

The leading indicators worth watching

The goal is to see drift while it is still small. A handful of measurements, tracked over time, will reveal most problems early:

- **Cushion and injection time.** Variation in the screw cushion or in fill time often signals changes in material viscosity before any part defect appears.
- **Melt flow rate on molded parts.** Comparing the melt flow of ground parts against virgin pellets is one of the most direct checks on degradation from moisture, residence time or regrind. A rising ratio is an early warning.
- **Part weight.** A simple, sensitive measure of process consistency. Weight trends often lead dimensional problems.
- **Moisture content at the press.** Measured at the hopper throat, not at the dryer, because that is what the material actually carries into the barrel.
- **Process parameters change log.** Every adjustment, with a reason. A cluster of changes is often the clearest sign of an underlying problem.

A short investigation sequence

When scrap is already rising, the temptation is to adjust parameters until parts look right. A more reliable approach works through the chain in order:

- **Freeze the process.** Stop making compensating adjustments and document the current settings against the validated process.

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- **Check the material at the press.** Moisture, melt flow and, for filled grades, filler content and fiber length. Compare against the incoming lot and the qualified baseline.
- **Check the equipment against its displays.** Verify actual melt temperature with a probe, dryer dew point and airflow, mold surface temperatures and check ring condition.
- **Examine the defective parts.** Fracture surfaces, sectioning for voids and fiber orientation, and dimensional mapping reveal whether the problem is material degradation, filling and packing, or cooling.
- **Return to the validated window.** Once the cause is corrected, restore the qualified settings rather than keeping the accumulated compensations.

This sequence often finds the cause within days. More importantly, it fixes the cause rather than hiding it again.

Why this matters beyond scrap

Degraded material does not always produce visible defects. A PA66 bracket molded from wet or over-ground material can pass dimensional inspection and fail months later in a vehicle when it meets heat, vibration and road chemicals. Brittle polycarbonate lens housings can crack in the field rather than on the line. Process drift is therefore a reliability and liability issue, not only a cost issue. When an automotive component fails in service, molding records, regrind logs and dryer data are among the first documents a customer or a court will ask for.

When drift has already reached the customer

If drift is discovered after suspect parts have shipped, the response becomes a containment exercise as much as an engineering one. Automotive customers expect a structured problem-solving report, and the credibility of that report depends on evidence. Three questions need clear answers. Which production window is affected, and how do you know where it starts and ends? Is the degradation detectable on parts already in the field, for example by melt flow testing of retained or returned samples? And what is the realistic failure risk of affected parts in service, given their load, temperature and chemical exposure?

Retained samples from each production lot are invaluable here. A plant that keeps a few parts per shift, labeled and stored, can bracket an affected window precisely and often show that the problem is narrower than feared. A plant without them may have to treat months of output as suspect. An independent assessment of the evidence can also help when the customer and supplier disagree

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about scope or cause, because a quality dispute between trading partners is easier to resolve with data both sides trust.

Building drift resistance into the process

The most effective defenses are mundane and inexpensive: a documented process window with defined limits; regrind limits that are measured and enforced; moisture checks at the press; periodic melt flow comparisons on production parts; and a rule that process changes are logged and reviewed rather than made silently. Combined, they turn drift from a months-long mystery into a weekly data point.

If scrap is creeping up, a qualified part is behaving differently, or you need an independent review of a molding process, Flaney Associates provides manufacturing process optimization for automotive and industrial manufacturers. Discuss Your Challenge at flaneyassociates.com/contact.html, or Get the Checklist at flaneyassociates.com/checklist.html.

Written by Joshua U. Otaigbe, PhD

Talk to us about your materials challenge

Joshua U. Otaigbe, PhD · Materials Engineering Consultant
info@flaneyassociates.com · +1 (601) 402-7282
flaneyassociates.com

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